INTRODUCTION

An Experimental Life

Gandhi's presence in the twentieth century, a century that perfected the art of extermination, is weirdly arresting. His life seems peculiarly unhoused in the violent landscape of his times. How, by what twist of historical fate, did this frail, ungainly man with teapot ears, whose figure wrapped in handspun cloth evoked a faded, archetypal memory of saintliness, wander into the modern world; and how, for a time, did he electrify it? What was he doing there, and what can the trace of his presence mean to us today?

More than fifty years after his assassination in 1948, Gandhi has become a symbol, a myth, even a commodity. Yet we are still far from taking the measure of the twentieth century's most enigmatic and remarkable personality. Confronted by the vast corpus of his writings and speeches (the *Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi* make up a hundred-volume monument), interpreters continue to quarrel, seeing him variously as a spiritual paragon, a wily politician, a psychological and anthropological curiosity, an inventor of political techniques of non-violence and civil disobedience, or as a critic of modernity.

But perhaps a safer clue to understanding Gandhi is to be found in his famous plea: 'My writings should be cremated with